

CITY OF DETROIT — PLANNING &
DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT

Spirit Plaza

*A Public Space Pilot
Data Collection Report*

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Period: Summer 2017 – Summer 2018

Location: Woodward Ave. between Jefferson Ave.
& Larned St., Detroit, MI

Method: Intercept Surveys & Pedestrian Counts

248

Total Survey
Participants

114

Pre-Activation
Surveys

134

Post-Activation
Surveys

81%

Respondents
Wanted Plaza
Made Permanent

Why Close the Road for a Plaza?

The space in front of the Spirit of Detroit Statue has long been a gathering place for Detroiters — to celebrate victories, protest injustices, and come together as one community. The activation of this space sought to provide a permanent civic space that Detroiters could claim as their own.

Community & Cultural Value

1

The closure created a dedicated civic space rooted in Detroit's cultural identity — building on the Spirit of Detroit Statue's role as a symbol of community gathering, protest, and celebration.

Safety & Mobility

2

By redirecting traffic from Woodward to Larned Street, the project reduced potential vehicle-pedestrian conflicts and crashes, improving safety and mobility for all users navigating Downtown and the Riverfront.



Spirit Plaza, summer 2017. The activated block of Woodward Ave. between Jefferson and Larned, with painted street murals, planters, seating, and the Spirit of Detroit statue at center.

Data Before & After the Closure

The City of Detroit Planning Department conducted intercept surveys and pedestrian counts in two phases — before and after the plaza's activation — to measure the impact of the road closure on public space use. Data was collected over multiple days in May 2017 (pre-activation) and July 2017 (post-activation).

248

Total Participants
Across Both Phases

114

Pre-Activation
May 2017 — 3 Days

134

Post-Activation
July 2017 — 3 Days



Intercept Surveys

Surveyed passersby on demographics, purpose of visit, time spent, and preferences for future programming.



Pedestrian Counts

Counted foot traffic by time of day — morning, lunch, afternoon, and Saturday — to understand usage patterns.



Activity Mapping

Mapped the spatial distribution and behaviors of plaza users across four quadrants of the site.



Posture Coding

Used a standardized posture coding system (S, PH, SM, FT, etc.) to categorize observed behaviors.

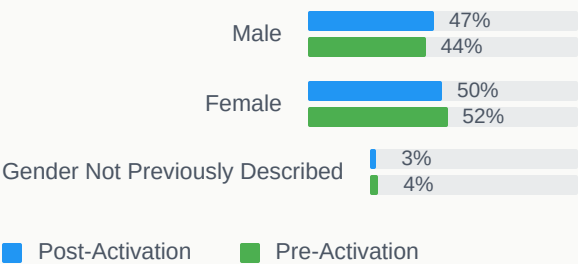


Intercept surveys in progress at Spirit Plaza. Respondents were asked about visit purpose, time spent, demographics, and programming preferences.

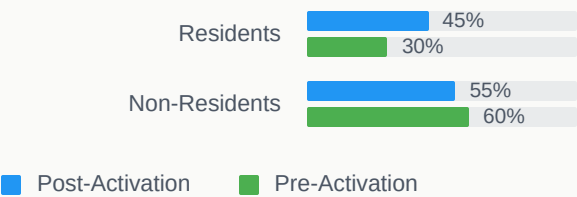
Respondent Demographics

Surveys captured gender, age, race, residency, and employment status to understand whose needs the plaza was serving — and how that shifted after activation.

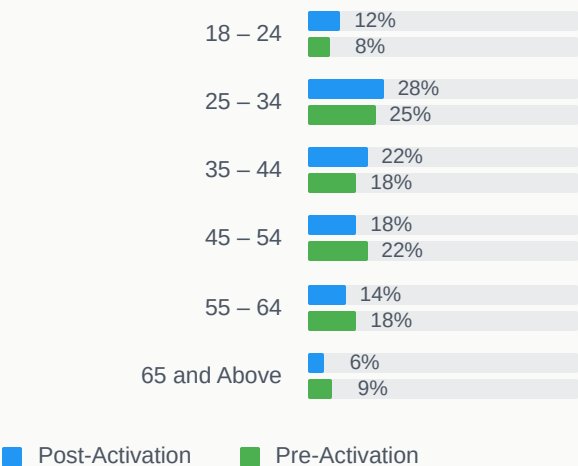
Gender of Respondents



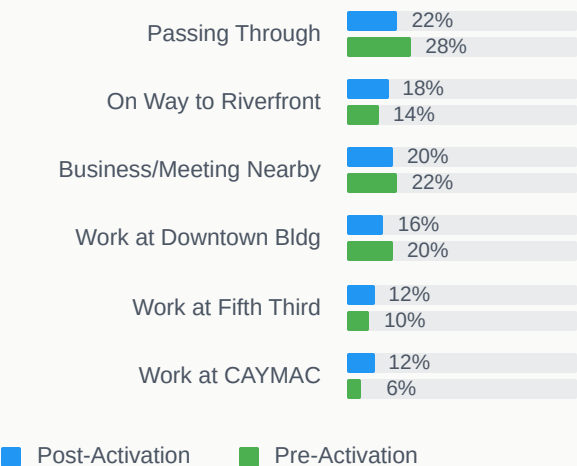
Residency of Respondents



Age of Respondents



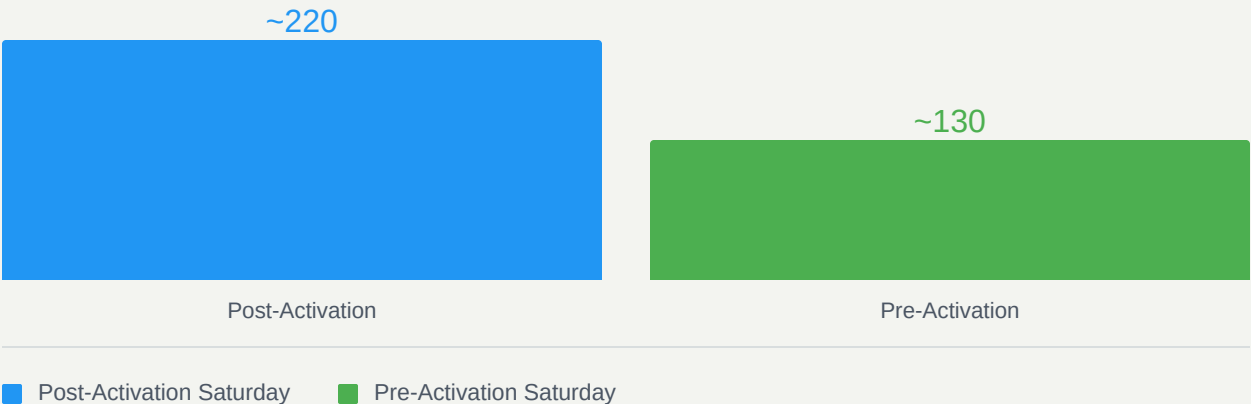
Reason for Being in the Plaza



Activity Patterns by Time of Day

Pedestrian counts and activity mapping were conducted across multiple time windows to understand how plaza use varied throughout the day and week. The post-activation Saturday count showed a dramatic increase in foot traffic.

Saturday Snapshot — Pedestrian Count



Morning Hours

Approx. 8am – 11am

55 25 12
High Average Low

Most visitors were sitting or taking photos — waiting for transit, court appointments, or taking a break from nearby offices.

Weekday Lunch

11am – 2pm

101 54 27
High Average Low

Peak usage period. Most visitors were waiting for food trucks or eating — drawn from surrounding office buildings and downtown businesses.

Weekday

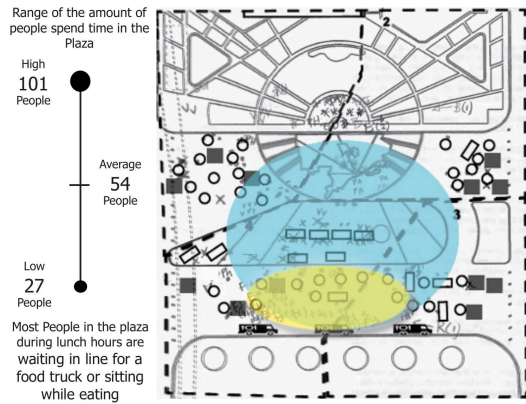
Afternoon

2pm – 5pm

69 42 23
High Average Low

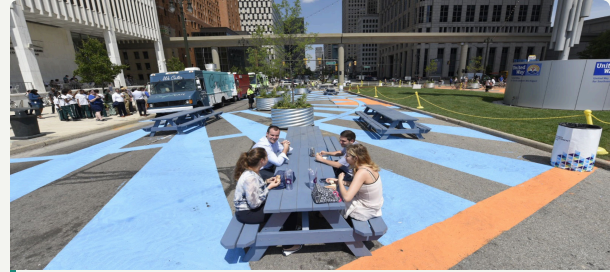
Evening commuters resting before heading home. Activities included sitting, conversing, and watching events near the Spirit of Detroit Statue.

Spirit Plaza Weekday Lunch Time In the Plaza 11am-2pm



POSTURE	DESCRIPTION	POSTURE	DESCRIPTION	POSTURE	DESCRIPTION
●	SITTING	← RB	NOT STOPPED DRIVING BIKE	□	PICNIC TABLE
PM	TALKING/STANDING WHILE STANDING/SEATING	→ RB	STOPPED DRIVING BIKE	○	ROUND TABLE
SM	SMOKING WHILE STANDING/SEATING	→ PA	PLAYING ADULT	■	STATUARY PLANTER
A	CONVERSING WITH SOMEONE WHILE SITTING	PD	PLAYING CHILD	■	FOOD TRUCK
V	CONVERSING WITH SOMEONE WHILE STANDING	SA	PARTICIPATION IN SPECIAL ACTIVITY		
X	TAKING PHOTOS	FT	WAITING IN LINE FOR FOODTRUCK		
X	EATING WHILE SITTING	SNB	STANDING SEATING AND WATCHING EVENT		
BK	READING/DRIVING COPY MATERIALS WHILE SITTING	W	WHEELCHAIR/ROLLER		
B	SKATING	PS	PLAYING STROLLER		
R	FOGGING/RUNNING				

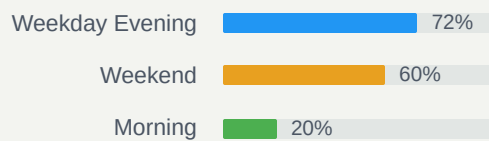
Spirit Plaza - Data Collection | 10



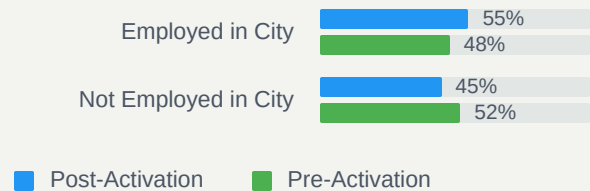
The plaza in active use during lunch — picnic-table seating, food-truck queues, and outdoor business meetings.

Spatial-use mapping with posture coding during weekday lunch. Activity concentrated near the food trucks and central seating, with a peak of 101 users observed.

Preferred Programming Times



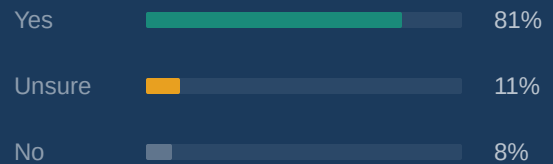
Employment Status of Respondents



81%

of respondents said Spirit Plaza
should be made permanent

*"Should Spirit Plaza be made a
permanent public space?"*



Summer 2018 Data Overview

From intercept surveys and site mapping conducted across the summer of 2018, Spirit Plaza emerged as a genuinely inclusive civic space — drawing residents and non-residents, workers and visitors, across all age groups and throughout the full day.

"Spirit Plaza is a space that bridges communities and helps close the class gap by providing public space that is convenient for all Detroiters to spend time in."

Unlike most public spaces in Detroit, Spirit Plaza attracted users from infancy to seniors — activated by its food trucks, seating, public art, and cultural programming. With a new mural of the City of Detroit, children engaged with the space in ways rarely seen in downtown public environments.

01

Foot Traffic Increased Significantly After Activation

Saturday pedestrian counts rose dramatically post-activation. Lunch hour peak counts reached 101 people — nearly double the morning low — confirming the plaza as a destination, not just a pass-through.

02

The Plaza Served a Broader, More Diverse Community

Post-activation surveys showed an increase in Detroit resident usage alongside non-residents, reflecting the plaza's growing role as a shared civic space rather than one serving a single demographic.

03

Food Trucks Were the Primary Activation Driver at Lunch

The most common behavior during peak hours was waiting in line for food trucks or eating. Food programming was the single strongest attractor for sustained plaza use.

04

Overwhelming Community Support for Permanence

81% of post-activation respondents supported making Spirit Plaza a permanent space. Only 8% opposed it — a clear signal of community ownership and satisfaction with the space as redesigned.

05

Evening & Weekend Programming Most Desired

72% of respondents preferred weekday evening programming, with weekend events also highly desired. Morning programming showed the least demand, pointing to where future investment would have the most impact.

06

The Space Bridged Economic & Social Divides

Spirit Plaza attracted people from all walks of life — office workers, transit riders, families, seniors, and children. Its design created conditions for cross-community encounter rarely achieved in urban public space.